INTERNAL

TVF Lead Engine

What it does and how it works, in plain language

21 September 2026

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What it does

The TVF Lead Engine finds companies worth talking to, works out who to write to, and drafts the email. A person approves every email before it goes out.

Without it, someone would have to search the web for companies, check whether each one is a fit, find the right person's email address, write to them one by one, and keep track of who replied. The engine does all of that legwork, every week, on its own. People make the two decisions that matter: which companies to pursue, and which emails are allowed to go out.

It runs four separate projects, each with its own sources, checklist and email wording:

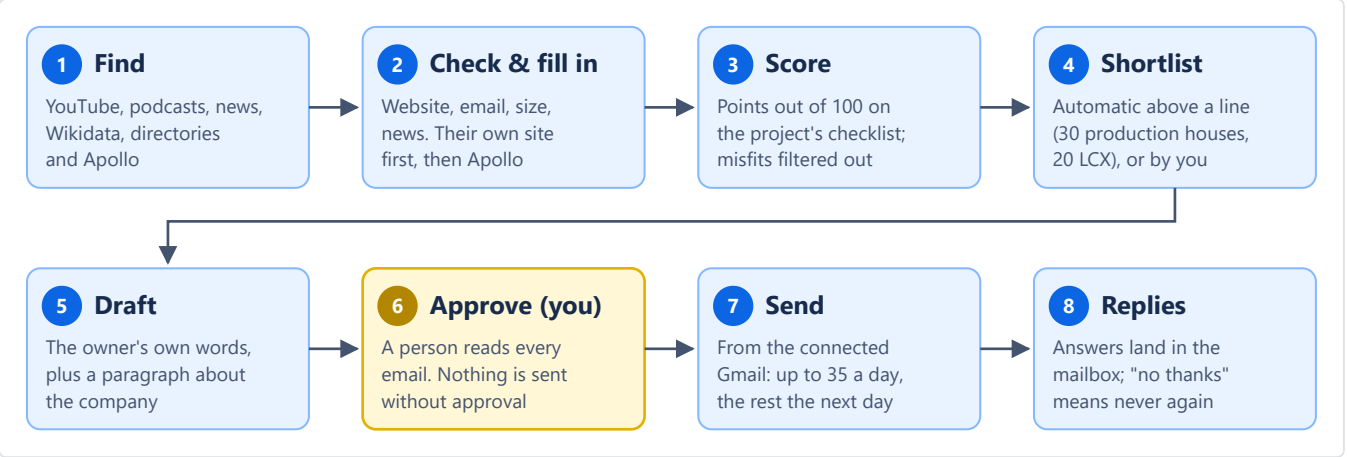
PROJECT	WHO IT LOOKS FOR	WHY
US Production Houses	Independent US film and TV production companies	Co-productions, format and IP partnerships with TVF
LCX Clipping	Podcasts and YouTube creators with long videos and few short ones	Selling LCX's service of cutting long videos into short clips
Startup Acquisitions	Indian startups in the news for layoffs, shutdowns or rescue rounds	Spotting companies that may be open to an acquisition
Universal	Anyone you search for in Apollo	A free-form search: any segment, any place

Where it stands today (21 September 2026):

- **2,841 companies and creators found:** 865 production houses, 1,657 shows and creators, 319 startups.
- **1,785 people and email addresses on file.**
- **66 production-house emails drafted** and waiting for approval, sent from vedanshg@theviralfever.com once approved.
- Sending is switched on for US Production Houses only, up to **35 emails a day**. The other projects are paused for now.
- **2,483 Apollo credits left** this month, out of 2,500.

How a lead travels

Every lead goes through the same eight steps. The engine does the blue ones by itself. The yellow one is always a person.



The eight steps from a name on the internet to a reply

1. Find

The engine looks in public places where the right kind of company shows up:

- **Wikidata**, the free database behind Wikipedia: 342 production houses that list an official website.
- **The AICP directory** of US commercial production companies: 247.
- **Google News headlines** about format deals, co-productions and series orders: 143 production houses and all 319 startups.
- **YouTube and Apple Podcasts:** channels and shows, with their audience size and how often they post.
- **Apollo**, a paid business database of people and companies, when you search it yourself in the Universal project.

When the same company turns up in two places, it becomes **one lead, not two**. The engine matches it by website, then by name, and keeps what each source said about it.

2. Check and fill in

A name alone is not much use, so the engine fills in what is missing:

- **The website**, if the source did not give one.
- **Who to write to.** It reads the company's own website first, the contact page and the team page. This is free, and it respects each site's rules (robots.txt). For production houses scoring above 22.5 that still have nobody to write to, it then asks Apollo for the best person's verified work email, which costs one credit per person found.
- **Evidence for the score:** team size, what kind of work they make, whether they invite partnerships, and any news about deals.

3. Score

Each project has a **checklist**, and each item on it is worth points. For production houses:

WHAT IT CHECKS	POINTS
Has adapted or co-produced international shows or formats	30
Has a live relationship with a streamer, network or big platform	20
The right size: a lean team of about 2 to 20 people	20
Makes the kind of stories TVF makes (comedy, slice-of-life, young adult)	15
Is open to collaborating: says so, or has a co-production record	15
A named decision-maker we can reach by email	10

The total becomes a **score out of 100**. A few things take points off, such as a portfolio full of advertising work for brands. Some things rule a company out completely: it is not in the US, it is a major studio, or it has stopped operating.

Every lead shows **why it scored what it did**: its strengths, what is still unknown, any risks, and the next step. Nothing is a black box.

4. Shortlist

A shortlisted lead is one worth writing to. Above a set line this happens by itself: **above 30 for production houses** and above 20 for LCX. Leads between 25 and 30 wait for a person to decide. If you reject a lead, it never comes back, whichever source finds it again.

5. Draft

For every shortlisted lead with an address, the engine writes an email. It uses the project's approved wording (for production houses, **the owner's own sample emails, word for word**) and adds one paragraph about that particular company, written from what the company says about itself on its own website. Production-house emails come from Vedansh, writing on Kartikeya's behalf, and end with the company's postal address and a one-line way to opt out.

6. Approve (always a person)

Nothing is sent until a person has read that exact email and pressed Approve. This is the one gate that every email must pass. You can edit a draft before approving it.

7. Send

Approved emails go out from a real Gmail mailbox, **at most 35 a day** for production houses. Approve more than that and the rest go out the next day, oldest first. A counter at the top of the Outreach page shows how many have gone out today, and how many are waiting.

8. Replies

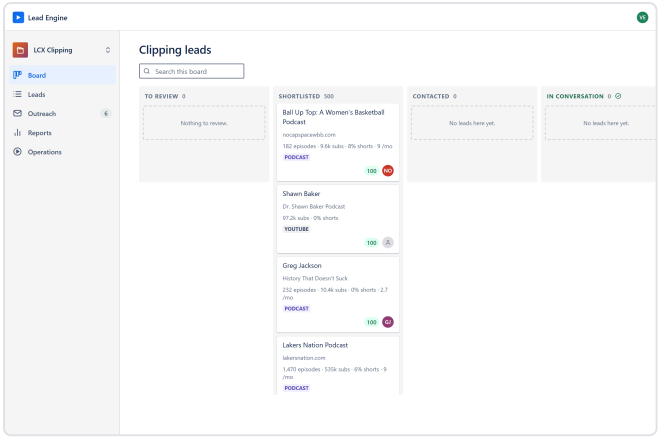
Replies land in the same mailbox, and the engine records them against the lead. Anyone who replies "no thanks" is never written to again.

What you see

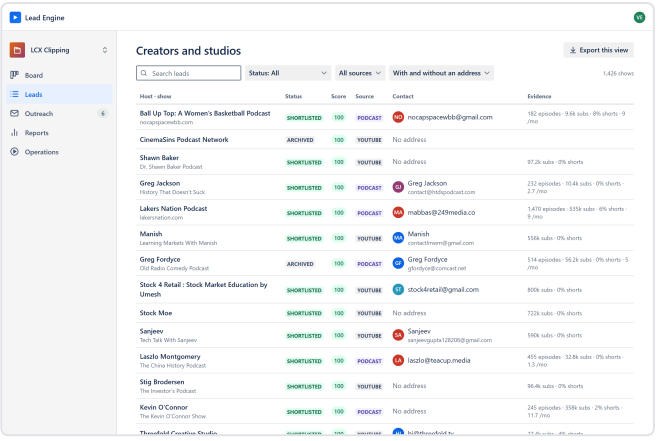
The app is a website with a login. It has the same five pages in every project:

- **Board:** leads as cards in columns: to review, shortlisted, contacted, in conversation.
- **Leads:** the same leads as a list, with filters (status, source, "has an address") and a download to Excel.
- **Outreach:** drafts, approved emails, sent emails and replies, with a counter showing how many emails went out today.
- **Reports:** how many were found, shortlisted, contacted and replied.
- **Operations:** when the engine last ran and whether anything went wrong.

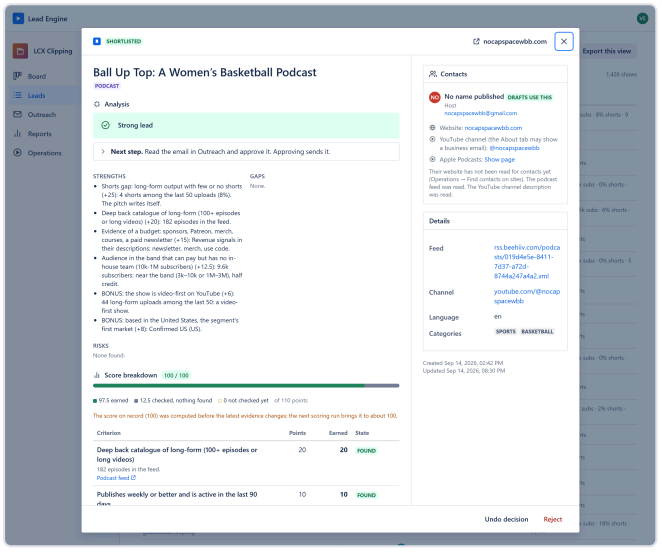
The Universal project has one more page: a search of Apollo, where you type a segment and a place, such as *US arcades*, and save the companies or people you want.



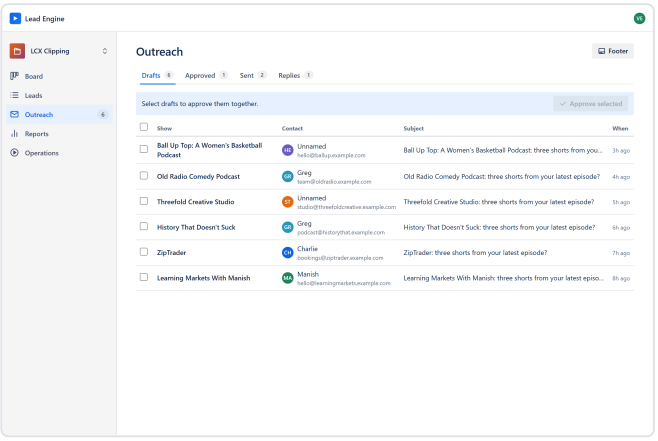
The board: each column is a stage, each card a lead.



The leads list, with its filters and the Excel download.



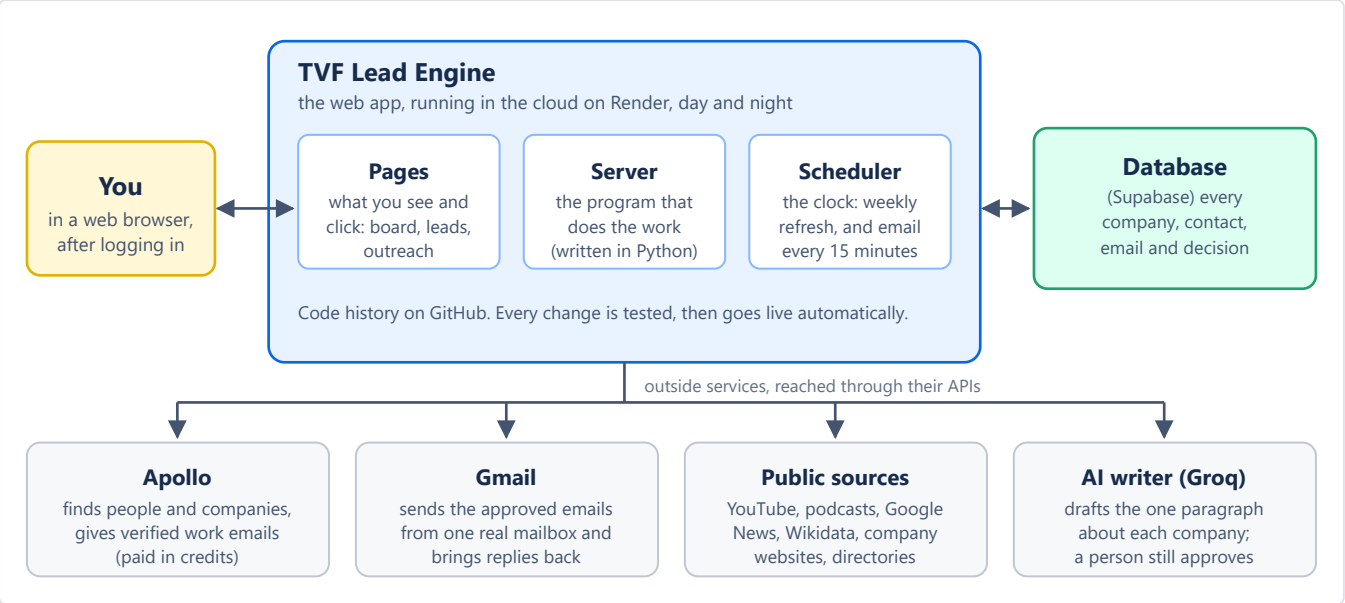
A lead: its score explained point by point, and who to write to.



Outreach: drafts waiting for approval.

How it is built

The engine is a few parts that work together. None of them needs anyone's computer to be switched on.



How the parts connect

The web app is the program itself. It runs on **Render**, a company that rents out computers in the cloud, so it is on 24 hours a day at tvf-lead-engine.onrender.com. It has two halves:

- **The pages** are what your browser shows: the board, the lists and the buttons.
- **The server** is the part that does the work: searching, scoring, drafting and sending. It is written in **Python**, a common programming language.

The scheduler is a clock inside the server. Once a week it runs the full refresh for each project: production houses on Tuesday at 7:30 am India time, LCX on Wednesday, startups on Thursday. Every 15 minutes it drafts emails for newly shortlisted leads and sends whatever has been approved.

The database is **Supabase**. It is where everything is kept: every company, person, email, score and decision. Think of it as a set of very large, very fast spreadsheets that the app reads and writes.

Outside services are other companies' systems that the engine talks to through their **APIs**. An API is a doorway one program uses to ask another for something. Each one needs a key, which is like a password for a program:

- **Apollo:** people and companies, and verified work emails.
- **Gmail:** sending the approved emails and collecting replies.
- **YouTube, Apple Podcasts, Google News, Wikidata:** the public sources.
- **Groq:** an AI model that writes the one paragraph about each company. A person still reads and approves every email.

Keys and passwords are never written into the code. They are stored in Render's private settings (called environment variables) and in a private file on the laptop that is never shared.

Settings, not code. Each project has a settings file: the checklist and its points, the shortlisting line, the email wording and the daily limit. Changing a number there changes how the engine behaves, without rewriting the program.

Changes are safe to make. Every version of the code is kept on **GitHub**, so any change can be seen and undone. Before a change goes live, automatic tests check that the important behaviour still holds; there are hundreds of these checks. Once a change is saved to GitHub, Render puts it live within a few minutes.

How Gmail is connected. Vedansh signed in to Google once and clicked **Allow**. Google then gave the app a **token**. It works like a valet key: the app can send email and read replies in that one mailbox, but it never sees the password, and the access can be withdrawn at any time from the Google account.

Why emails reach the inbox. Email providers check that a message really comes from the domain it claims to. theviralfever.com has two of the three standard proofs set up (called SPF and DKIM). This is why sending is from a theviralfever.com address, and why adding the third proof (DMARC) is on the to-do list.

The rules that keep it safe

These rules are built into the database itself, not just the screens, so they hold even if something else goes wrong:

- **No email goes out unless a person approved it.** There is no "approve all without reading".
- **One conversation per company, ever.** Production houses get one email. LCX gets at most one email and two follow-ups in the same thread, and any reply stops the follow-ups.
- **A rejected lead never comes back**, whichever source finds it again.
- **"No thanks" is permanent.** That company is never written to again.
- **Nothing is claimed that the evidence does not support.** Every sentence about a company comes from what was actually found about it.
- **Only public information, politely gathered.** Only public pages are read, and websites' robots.txt rules are respected. There is no LinkedIn scraping and no bought email lists.
- **Paid credits are spent only where the owner switched them on**, for production houses scoring above 22.5. Searching is free.
- **Sending stays gentle:** at most 35 a day from one mailbox, well below Gmail's own limit of 2,000, because a mailbox that sends too many cold emails gets treated as spam.

Tech words, explained simply

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS HERE
Web app	A program you use through a web browser instead of installing it.
Server	The computer, and the program on it, that does the work behind the pages.
Cloud / hosting (Render)	Renting a computer that is always on, instead of using our own.
Database (Supabase)	Where all the information is kept, organised in tables of rows.
API	The doorway one program uses to ask another program for something.
API key	A password that lets our program use another company's API.
Environment variables	The safe place on the server where keys are kept, out of the code.
Scheduler	The built-in clock that starts jobs at set times, like the weekly refresh.
Pipeline	A fixed series of steps run in order: find, check, score, and so on.
Enrichment	Filling in facts a lead is missing: website, email, size, news.
Scraping (polite)	Reading a company's own public web pages for details like a contact address, while obeying the site's rules.
Score / rubric	The checklist a lead is marked against, and the points it earns.
Credits (Apollo)	Apollo's currency: 1 credit for each verified email revealed, 1 for each page of company results.
OAuth / token	Google's way of letting the app send from a mailbox without ever knowing its password.
SPF, DKIM, DMARC	Three records on a domain that prove its emails are genuine. They help mail land in the inbox.
AI model (Groq)	A text-writing program that drafts one paragraph per email. A person approves every email.
GitHub / commit	The code's history. Each saved change is a commit, and any commit can be looked at or undone.
Deploy	Putting the latest version of the code live. Here it happens automatically.
Test	An automatic check that a behaviour still works, run before each change goes live.
Daily cap	The most emails a project may send in a day.

Where things stand, and what is next

Ready now

- 66 production-house emails are drafted, signed and waiting for approval.
- The footer (sign-off, postal address and opt-out line) is filled in.
- The Gmail mailbox vedanshg@theviralfever.com is connected on the laptop.
- Apollo is connected and finding contacts for good production houses on its own.

To do before the first email goes out

1. Add the four Gmail values to Render's private settings, so the server can send, not just the laptop.
2. Read and approve the drafts in Outreach.

Worth doing soon

- Add the DMARC record for theviralfever.com, so more email lands in the inbox.
- Start the production-house searches again. No new production houses have come in since late August, because those searches ran on the laptop. Moving them onto the server would make them weekly and automatic.
- Connect LCX's own sending mailboxes and lift its pause when that project is ready to start.